

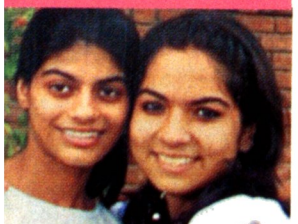
THE AWESOME FOURSOME



Fiza (left) and
Aarushi

**"She was such
an introvert and
always the
peace-loving one
amongst us."**

VIDUSHI DURRANI
FRIEND



Sanshe (left) with
Vidushi

**"All the stories
about her have
hurt us. She was
good at whatever
she did."**

SANSHE BHATIA,
FRIEND

The mother-daughter were close enough to argue constantly (in a mother's day card in 2007, Aarushi writes, in typical SMS-speak, "We have had a gazillion fights, a million 'I will never talk to you'. But after all u r the one who will always be there for me") but also for true confessions. Nupur knew Aarushi had a boyfriend and even that she had broken up with her previous one, who was trying to win her back. She tried to be her friend but was not averse to unilateral monitoring, whether it was looking into her SMSes or e-mail accounts. So why should such a gleaming advertisement for happy family values go so horribly wrong? Why should such picture postcard parents be transformed into baby-killers?

It's not just police ham-handedness. Even two months after the murder, there are several unanswered questions, the prime among them being how could the Talwars not hear their daughter's screams from the bedroom next door in a 1,525 sq ft flat? The CBI claims they have done two sound tests that prove the air-conditioner in the parents' room was very noisy. But would Hemraj be so bold as to invite three friends into his employers' home for a drink from their stock of Scotch? Talwars' relatives now say the co-accused, Rajkumar, would often come home in the afternoons when no one from the family was present. If Krishna, Talwar's compounder, did indeed precipitate Aarushi's killing, was his motive—that he was upset at being scolded in public by Rajesh Talwar—powerful enough? Clearly, not only were the Talwars deep sleepers, they were also quite trusting of their help. In the absence of

crucial evidence, a straightforward mystery has been reduced to a 'blind case' as the CBI puts it.

The answers look like they will be a long time coming. But for everyone connected with Aarushi, nothing will be the same again. The 43-year-old Nupur, unable to shed a single tear, pleads that they be seen as the "doting, caring parents" they were. For Talwar, the attempt is to clear his name, something his elder brother, eye surgeon Dinesh Talwar, says is a priority. Their lawyer, senior counsel Pinaki Mishra (Talwar was his

crowding television channels. For Vidushi, doubly-scarred by her best friend's death and her parents' reputation being dragged through the mud, it is something she is desperately trying to put behind her. "We would always meet during the break in school, and whenever one of us was absent, we would feel incomplete," she says. "Now we will always feel that way." For the fourth member of the Awesome Foursome, Sanshe Bhatia, a scholar blazer holder like the rest, Aarushi, who had joined her science tuition three

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MEDIA OVERKILL: Rajesh with his brother Dinesh Talwar (left) after he was released from police custody

dentist) says the savagery with which he was pilloried will take a long time to live down.

The stigma may well remain even if freedom comes. For Aarushi's friends, the loss has affected them differently. Fiza, daughter of journalist Padmanand Jha and his publisher wife Masooma (who has emerged as the Talwars' unlikely media manager), talking about her is cathartic. Fiza was the photographer of the group and it is her pictures of a girl with curly hair and flashing kohl-rimmed eyes (Nupur says Aarushi had just discovered make-up) that are

months ago, is a memory "no one can take away from us". For her vice-principal, Sarita Madhok, she was the ideal student whose work was as meticulous as her presentation.

And what of Aarushi? A clip from a home video, shot when the parents were driving to the Jim Corbett Park with the Durrani, has Nupur urging her daughter to behave like a celebrity. Aarushi blows kisses into the camera, waving to her imaginary fans. It is the most poignant image of an unfinished life.

with Chitra
Subramanyam and Deepika Khatri